4

BRICS, capital-imperialism and new contradictions

Virginia Fontes

Understanding the emergence of a group of countries such as the BRICS requires a wide-ranging reflection on contemporary capitalism's transformations and the spelling out of new economic, political and, above all, social contradictions. In this chapter we briefly present a set of characteristics that we call capital-imperialism. We start from the premise that the required analysis of diverse national contexts needs to take into account not only the interaction of domestic social sectors but also their increasing internationalisation. Today the influence (and predominance) of centre countries has to be seen not just as something external but as profoundly and unequally internalised in the other countries. External obligations do not diminish as there is a strong pressure for subordinate countries – such as the BRICS – to adhere to the modes of capital-imperialist expansion. This process generates new tensions that need clarification to be overcome.

If any coherence exists among the BRICS countries – countries that are historically, culturally, geographically and economically disparate – is it manifest in an international trend on behalf of a broad humanitarian project? Or do the BRICS countries come together to guarantee themselves a place in the present international order, not to subvert it, but to secure room at the top of the pyramid for at least their dominant classes and enriched elites? A more reasonable expectation seems to be that the BRICS member-states demonstrate new contradictions.

Whatever role they come to play in spite of their inconsistency, their very